

Chapter One

The Sister Nora Chose

Nora Reyes had always believed that some absences grew with you.

They did not stay small, the way people expected childhood wounds to stay small. They stretched. They learned your shape. They followed you into adulthood and sat quietly beside you at dinner tables, birthdays, weddings, hospital waiting rooms. They became the silence after someone said, “Do you have any siblings?” and waited for an answer simple enough to fit into conversation.

Nora did have siblings.

Two older brothers, in fact.

Daniel and Luis had filled her childhood with noise, arguments, slammed doors, half-eaten cereal, and the heavy, careless affection of boys who loved her but did not always know what to do with a younger sister. They protected her fiercely when protection was needed, teased her endlessly when it was not, and treated every emotional conversation like a room they had accidentally walked into and wanted to leave politely.

Nora loved them.

She did.

But loving her brothers had never erased the quiet wanting that lived inside her.

She had wanted a sister.

Someone who understood the secret language of small things. Someone who would sit on the bathroom floor with her after a bad day. Someone who would borrow her clothes without asking, know when she was pretending to be fine, and say the exact wrong thing so honestly that it became the right thing.

As a child, Nora had imagined that sister into every empty space.

A girl beside her in the back seat during long car rides, while Daniel and Luis argued over music in the front. A second toothbrush by the bathroom sink. Someone to whisper with after midnight when her brothers were asleep and the house felt too large. Someone who would not tell her to “stop overthinking” because she would understand that thinking too much was sometimes the only way Nora knew how to feel safe.

She had imagined her so often that, by the time Maya Santos came into her life, Nora recognized her with the strange certainty of someone remembering a thing she had never had.

Maya arrived during Nora’s second year of university, late to a literature lecture, breathless, wearing two different earrings and carrying a coffee that had already spilled down the side of her hand.

“Is this seat taken?” Maya whispered.

Nora looked at the empty chair beside her.

“No.”

Maya dropped into it with a relieved sigh, then glanced at Nora’s notes. “You have beautiful handwriting.”

“You have coffee on your sleeve.”

Maya looked down. “That is also true.”

Nora laughed before she could stop herself.

That was how it began. Not with a dramatic rescue, not with a secret shared under moonlight, but with coffee, ink, and Maya’s complete inability to enter any room quietly.

Years later, Nora still thought of that moment whenever Maya let herself into her apartment without knocking.

“Nora?” Maya called from the hallway. “Before you judge me, I want you to remember that hunger makes people morally flexible.”

Nora looked up from the kitchen counter, where she was arranging small cakes onto a white ceramic plate. “What did you do?”

Maya appeared in the doorway holding a paper bag against her chest like stolen treasure. Her dark curls were damp from the rain, and her cheeks were flushed from the cold. “I bought pastries.”

“That does not sound morally flexible.”

“I used the emergency card.”

Nora froze. “The emergency card is for actual emergencies.”

Maya lifted the bag. “I was sad.”

“That is not an emergency.”

“It is when there is almond cream involved.”

Nora tried to look stern, but Maya’s expression was so solemn, so theatrical, that the laugh rose out of her before she could swallow it. Maya grinned immediately, triumphant.

“You are weak,” Maya said.

“For you, unfortunately.”

Maya crossed the kitchen and kissed Nora’s cheek, quick and warm. “That is why I keep you.”

Nora turned back to the cakes so Maya would not see how those words settled in her.

That is why I keep you.

Maya said things like that easily. Carelessly, almost. Her love was expressive, thrown over shoulders, pressed into hands, scattered across rooms. She could say “I love you” while searching for her phone, “I missed you” while stealing fries from someone’s plate, “You are my family” while half asleep on Nora’s couch.

Nora never knew how to answer with the same ease.

For her, love had weight. It was something to be held with both hands. Something breakable.

“You are early,” Nora said.

“I know. I wanted time with you before Adam arrives and starts being perfect.”

“He is not perfect.”

Maya gave her a look. “Nora, the man alphabetizes your spice cabinet when he is anxious.”

“That is not perfection. That is a cry for help.”

“It is terrifyingly attractive.”

Nora threw a napkin at her.

Maya caught it and pressed it dramatically to her heart. “You wound me in my own sister’s kitchen.”

Nora paused.

My sister.

Maya said it often now. Casually. Naturally. As if she had not changed the entire architecture of Nora’s life with those two words.

Nora turned away again, pretending to adjust the cakes.

“You okay?” Maya asked.

“Yes.”

“You did the quiet thing.”

“What quiet thing?”

“The one where you disappear while still standing in front of me.”

Nora smiled faintly. “I am just thinking.”

“Dangerous.”

“About how you are going to pay back the emergency card.”

Maya groaned and leaned against the counter. “Cruel woman.”

Before Nora could answer, the front door opened.

“Cruel woman?” Adam called from the hallway. “Should I come back?”

Maya pointed toward the sound. “See? Perfect timing. Like a responsible ghost.”

Adam Cruz entered the kitchen carrying a bottle of wine, rain caught in his black hair and along the shoulders of his coat. He had the calm presence of someone who made rooms feel less urgent simply by standing inside them.

Nora loved that about him.

The world could become sharp and loud around her, but Adam moved through it with a steadiness that made things seem survivable. He noticed what needed doing. He remembered details. He asked before touching when she was upset. He knew which silences wanted comfort and which wanted space.

When he saw her, his face softened.

“Hi,” he said.

It was ridiculous, how much one small word could still affect her after four years.

“Hi.”

He crossed the kitchen and kissed her, gentle and familiar.

Maya made a gagging sound behind them.

“Please,” Maya said. “Some of us are alone and fragile.”

Adam looked at the paper bag. “You bought pastries.”

“With my own money,” Maya said quickly.

Nora raised an eyebrow.

Maya sighed. “With emotionally justified money.”

Adam nodded as if this were reasonable. “Then I support you.”

“That is why I like you.”

“You like me because I fix your Wi-Fi.”

“That is also true.”

The evening unfolded the way Nora loved best.

Rain tapped softly against the windows. The kitchen filled with warmth, with the smell of sugar and coffee, with Maya’s laughter rising too loudly and Adam’s quieter replies beneath it. They ate dinner at the small round table Nora had bought secondhand and repainted herself. Maya complained about work. Adam told a story about a patient who had tried to diagnose himself using three different internet forums. Nora listened, smiling, letting their voices move around her like music.

This was the life she had built.

No, not built.

Chosen.

There was a difference.

A built life could be planned, measured, secured. A chosen life depended on people choosing you back. Again and again. Day after day.

That was the part Nora rarely said aloud.

Her brothers loved her because she belonged to them by blood. There was comfort in that. A rough, permanent comfort. But Maya and Adam had chosen her without obligation. That made their love feel miraculous.

It also made it feel terrifying.

She trusted Maya. She trusted Adam. She did.

But sometimes, in moments of happiness, a strange fear opened beneath her. Not because anything was wrong, but because everything was so right. Because joy gave the future something to take.

After dinner, Adam washed the dishes despite Nora's protests. Maya sat cross-legged on the counter, eating the last almond pastry straight from the bag.

"You know," Maya said, licking sugar from her thumb, "when you two get married, I should give a speech."

Adam glanced over. "Should?"

"Will," Maya corrected. "I will give a speech."

Nora narrowed her eyes. "That sounds threatening."

"It will be beautiful."

"That sounds more threatening."

Maya smiled, but something flickered across her face.

It was brief. So brief Nora almost missed it.

A shadow behind the eyes. A tightening around the mouth. Maya looked down at the pastry bag, folding the paper edge between her fingers.

Adam did not notice. He was rinsing a plate.

Nora did.

"What is it?" she asked.

Maya looked up too quickly. "What?"

"You looked..."

"Tired," Maya said. "I am tired."

Nora studied her. "Are you sure?"

"Yes." Maya hopped down from the counter. "It has been a long week."

There it was again. Not a lie exactly. But not the whole truth.

Nora felt the old instinct rise in her, quiet and immediate. The need to move closer. To hold. To ask until the hidden thing revealed itself.

But Maya smiled before she could.

“Do not make that face,” Maya said.

“What face?”

“The face that says you are about to love me aggressively.”

Adam laughed softly from the sink.

Nora forced herself to smile. “Fine. I will love you passively.”

“Much better.”

But the moment had already changed something in the room.

Not enough for anyone else to name. Not enough to ruin the evening. But enough for Nora to feel it under her skin.

Later, after Maya left and Adam went to take a shower, Nora stood alone in the kitchen.

The apartment was quiet now. Too quiet, the way rooms became after laughter left them. She wiped the counter though it was already clean. She folded the napkin Maya had used. She threw away the empty pastry bag, then pulled it out of the trash again because Maya had doodled a small heart on the corner.

Under the heart, Maya had written:

For emergency sadness.

Nora smiled despite herself.

Then her phone buzzed.

A message from Maya.

Home. Don't worry. Love you, sister.

Nora stared at the word.

Sister.

Something in her chest loosened and hurt at the same time.

She typed back:

Love you too.

Then, after a moment, she added:

Always.

She put the phone down and pressed her palms against the counter.

For no clear reason, the kitchen seemed to tilt.

Nora blinked.

The lights above her blurred, stretching into long white lines. A sudden pressure filled her ears, as if she had been pulled underwater. She reached for the edge of the counter, but her fingers did not seem to obey her fast enough.

“Nora?”

Adam’s voice came from somewhere far away.

She tried to answer.

The room folded inward.

For one terrifying second, Nora felt herself falling without moving.

Then the kitchen vanished.

She was standing in the rain.

No.

Not standing.

Walking.

Her feet moved without her permission, splashing through shallow puddles on a dark sidewalk. Cold water touched her ankles. Her

breath came fast, but it was not her breath. Her hands clutched a phone, but they were not her hands.

Nora tried to scream.

No sound came.

A car passed, headlights flashing across wet pavement.

In the reflection of a shop window, Nora saw a woman walking alone beneath a black umbrella.

Maya.

Nora was inside Maya's body.

And Maya was crying.